

Chapter 3: Spellcasting

The arcane arts are as dangerous as they are powerful. This chapter details the rules for spellcasting, including spell slots, schools of magic, and casting times.

Preparing Spells

Spellcasters prepare their spells from a larger repertoire. A wizard, for example, maintains a spellbook containing all the spells they have learned. Each day, they prepare a subset of these spells equal to their Intelligence modifier plus their wizard level (minimum of one).

Clerics and druids prepare spells from their class spell list. They may change their prepared spells after a long rest. Warlocks and sorcerers, by contrast, know a limited number of spells and do not prepare spells daily — their known spells are always available.

Schools of Magic

Magic is divided into eight schools, each representing a different approach to manipulating the Weave:

Abjuration — Protective magic that creates barriers, negates attacks, and defends against harm.

Conjuration — Transporting creatures and objects, summoning allies, and creating matter.

Divination — Revealing knowledge, seeing distant places, and peering into the future.

Enchantment — Influencing minds and granting the caster power over others.

Evocation — Channeling raw magical energy to create destructive effects like fire and lightning.

Illusion — Deceiving the senses with false images, sounds, and sensations.

Necromancy — Manipulating life force, raising undead, and draining vitality.

Transmutation — Changing the properties of creatures, objects, and environments.

Spell Slots and Casting

Spells are categorized by level from 0 (cantrips) to 9. To cast a spell, you must expend a spell slot of the spell's level or higher. Cantrips are always available and do not require spell slots.

Casting a spell at a higher level than its base level is called *upcasting*. Many spells gain additional power when cast from higher-level slots — for example, increasing damage dice or targeting additional creatures.

Sample Spells

Magic Missile

1st-level evocation

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 120 feet

Components: V, S

Duration: Instantaneous

You create three glowing darts of magical force. Each dart hits a creature of your choice that you can see within range. A dart deals 1d4 + 1 force damage. All darts strike simultaneously. At Higher Levels: +1 dart per slot level above 1st.

Fireball

3rd-level evocation

Casting Time: 1 action

Range: 150 feet

Components: V, S, M (a tiny ball of bat guano and sulfur)

Duration: Instantaneous

A bright streak flashes from your finger to a point you choose within range and then blossoms with a low roar into an explosion of flame. Each creature in a 20-foot-radius sphere must make a Dexterity saving throw. A target takes 8d6 fire damage on a failed save, or half as much on a successful one.

Concentration

Some spells require concentration to maintain. You can concentrate on only one spell at a time. If you take damage while concentrating, you must make a Constitution saving throw to maintain concentration. The DC equals 10 or half the damage taken, whichever is higher. Concentration ends if you are incapacitated or begin concentrating on another spell.

Ritual Casting

Spells with the ritual tag can be cast without expending a spell slot, but the casting time increases by 10 minutes. Not all spellcasters can cast rituals — wizards, clerics, druids, and bards have this ability innately.